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The Surface Tension of Media

Texture, Canvas, Screen

You walk into the large space of a former New York City warehouse. You adjust your eyes to the ambience and access the mise-en-scène of Robert Irwin's *Excursus: Homage to the Square*³ (1998). There is a rigorous geometry to the architecture of the installation, and yet this seemingly still environment moves, activated over time by way of light. The scene you experience will depend on the time of day and the state of the weather. A product of decades of work with light and space, originating in Irwin's particular brand of Southern California minimalism, the installation engages the forms of canvas, wall, and screen in architectural inquiry.¹

The frame of this inquiry is announced in the title of the installation, which refers to *Homage to the Square*, the landmark series of paintings that Joseph Albers began in 1950 and carried on for twenty-five years. The large open space of the third floor of the Dia Center for the Arts appears transformed, as if the canvases that Albers conceived as architectures have materialized in actual architecture. Here Irwin exposes the potential of the square, using scrims to create eighteen similarly constructed rooms. Stretched and invisibly attached to frames, these scrims appear to function as walls; they not only form partitions but also create openings in the shape of doors. But these walls have a particular character. They are light, made of transparent fabric, and they defy the gravity of enclosure. As they dematerialize the tectonics of wall, such forms also materialize into another surface. The fabric of their lightness creates a veiled architecture and a subtly textured space.

These scrim-walls are made of a delicate fabric that is not only transparent but also translucent. The material is fundamentally luminous in the way it reflects and absorbs the natural and artificial light that constitutes an important part of the installation's architecture. At

4.1. Robert Irwin, *Excursus: Homage to the Square*³, 1998. Installation view, Dia Center for the Arts, New York, September 13, 1998–June 13, 1999. © 2012 Robert Irwin/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York. Photo: Thibault Jeanson. Courtesy of Dia Art Foundation, New York.

either end of the space there is a source of luminosity in the form of large windows, but, like the scrim-walls, these windows confound their given architecture. They are gel-covered such that they no longer simply frame the light but rather filter it. In creating another stratum of luminous filter, they act less like windows and more like sheer partitions: they too become scrims. Further illumination comes from fluorescent lights positioned within the space, their tubes wrapped in layers of theatrical gels that contribute an eerie, colored glow. This use of transparent plastic film further enhances the atmospheric effects of the installation, in clear homage to Albers's own painterly study of color textures and hues.

As you walk further into the space you become increasingly aware of its layered visual fabrication. Filtered through scrims that are essentially veils, light itself appears layered, coated, and textured. As a veil of light bathes the room with ambience, the atmosphere becomes as palpable as fabric and you sense its "weathering." This stratified environment is anything but static, and it is fundamentally temporal. Subtle shifts of luminosity occur over time, changing not only the tone but also the mood of the ambient space.

Immersed in the density of these superficial effects, your awareness of surfaces amplifies. You begin to sense the change of light on fabric as if it were affecting your own skin. A conflation of materials takes place on the texture of the scrims, which take on a cinematic form. The scrims effectively assume the meaning of *pellicule*, that is, of "film," celluloid—that material "skin" that itself reflects, absorbs, and responds to light.

The more the durational fabric of light is registered on the scrims, the more the force of the cinematic pervades the installation. As viewers walk through the layers of their architectural presence in the space, they too become part of the fabric of the installation.² Appearing and disappearing through the scrims, these viewers, like actors in a film, enter into a play of light and shadow, becoming shadows themselves. As the scrims activate this subtle play of transparency and shadowing, they "mediate" a spectatorial experience. The veils of these scrims activate rooms that are permeable viewing chambers. And thus, acting as luminous partitions and reflective filters, the scrim-walls are finally understood to be screens. They are the kind of transparent bodies that can enable projection, which is itself a form of transfer and mediation. Their absorbent material is that same fabric that allows a screen to be, in all senses of the word, a medium.

Wall, Canvas, Screen. As it unfolds in layers, or rather "sheets," of mediatic connections, Robert Irwin's installation embodies the main theoretical preoccupation of this study: the passages that occur across the material of canvas, wall, and screen. In these passages, we can witness how the status of the image has changed across time: images have come to be manifested more and more as surfaces. This issue of surface encounters, a thread throughout my critical approach to visuality, now comes to the fore. This core section of the book, on surfaces of light, is engaged in particular in reflecting on the presence and configuration of the screen as a cultural fabric. Irwin's installation offers us a way to signal that there are

shifts in the relations between media that appear reflected, and acted upon, on the surface of their material medium of communication. A depth of interesting phenomena of mediation emerges on the surface, which becomes highlighted in contemporary visual culture as a form of communication in itself—that is to say, as a medium. The surface is the locus for the intersection of diverse visual configurations and the site of the mediatic refashioning of visual fabrics. It also acts as a shifting depository of visual histories in the form of palpable sediments and passages of textural density.

Irwin's work suggests in particular that, as we think of images as surfaces, we must reflect on the "superficial" relation between the forms of canvas, wall, and screen, for the surface not only mediates their fabrication but also their modification. The hypothesis put forth here is that a fundamental intersection of these forms has taken place, and today we can witness an important change on the surface of media. The interrelation of these forms is changing on the surface, and as distinctions collapse a form of conflation between canvas, wall, and screen is taking place. Irwin's work is exemplary in that it shows that the very nature of what it is traditionally understood as canvas and wall has changed to incorporate a form that has become ever-present in our culture: the screen. As it "projects" the canvas into architecture, the installation also creates a more permeable understanding of the notion of wall. It shows that the wall has itself changed. The architecture of the wall is no longer rigidly tectonic but rather tensile and textured. Such a wall embodies the property of canvas and the configuration of screen.

The screen thus takes center stage. But it too appears in a fashion that differs from its usual framing. In fact, as we ponder the architecture of this installation, we may come to question canonical notions of the screen and thereby advance its theorization. It is important to review the architecture of this form, for the screen, when it does not remain undertheorized, has been too often treated in film theory as a trope akin to the window and the mirror. But the fabric of the screen discloses a change here. This screen is not a window. It slips away from any conceptual framing in pure perspectival geometry and ideal. And it is also not a mirror. This type of screen is not reflective of any form of split identity, and it supersedes the architecture of the Lacanian gaze. The screen, as it emerges here, is dressed as a different surface. It is rather reconfigured as a type of canvas, a sheet, or a curtain. Partition, shelter, and veil, this is a permeable architectural envelope.

In the following pages I want to pursue the idea of this interface, exposed here as it unfolds in Irwin's work, and explore it further to see how it emerges on the surface of different media. This chapter and the one that follows are in many ways, then, a continued meditation on surface, and on the layers of depth that it can hold. Since this is an inquiry into phenomena that are still evolving, it will take the form of an exploratory journey, collecting and assembling clusters of manifestations in different forms. As I interweave this material to present my thesis on surface and screen fabrics, I aim to render theoretically, in the tissue of the writing itself, the transformative agency and the thickness of surface. Because of the vast expanse of the material, I will keep the focus on a few textural readings of visual

4.2. Krzysztof Wodiczko, *The Hiroshima Projection*, 1999. Public projection at the A-Bomb Dome, Hiroshima, Japan. Courtesy of the artist and Galerie Lelong, New York.

works that engage in the idea of “surface tension,” threading a connection to architectural phenomena. What follows, then, is a speculative reflection on works that, in different ways, engage the intersection—and even the conflation—of canvas, wall, and screen, with the aim of demonstrating the varied potential of (screen) surface to mediate cultural fabrics, not only in media but as a new “old” medium itself.

Luminous Opacity: Screen, Window, Wall. A most compelling refashioning of surface as the site of a conceptual reconfiguration of wall, window, and screen resides in the work of Krzysztof Wodiczko, an artist known for his large-scale video and slide projections on architectural façades and planes. Since 1980, this Polish-born artist, who lives in New York City and Cambridge, Massachusetts, has produced more than eighty such public projections, in many different countries.³ His use of visual technology and new media is particularly relevant to my perspective, for Wodiczko has incessantly used the medium of projection to interrogate the face and façade of architecture as a dense surface: a permeable site for the mediation of memory, history, and subjectivity. Recently, turning the object of his long-standing investigation inside out, Wodiczko has architected works that further mediatic potentials in digital form.

Two related Wodiczko installations effectively play with the surface of interior and exterior space: *If You See Something . . .*, shown at New York City’s Galerie Lelong in 2005, and *Guests*, exhibited at the 2009 Venice Biennale. Both show a mise-en-scène that is lucidly complex. As one walked into the dark interior space of the Polish Pavilion of the Biennale, where *Guests* was installed, one thought one was seeing eight windows, scattered on three walls, and, looking up, one skylight. But in fact, the walls of the pavilion had no openings. Wodiczko carved out these frames not in stone but in imaging. The windows were actually projections, “screens” on which one could catch glimpses of life and the personal narratives of immigrants, the “guests” of a country. *If You See Something . . .* is similarly structured, with four windows projected along one side of the dark interior space of the gallery. Here too, this time in New York, one could access the narratives of society’s invisible citizens. Although they are overexposed in policing and immigration surveillance, the migrants in this installation, as in *Guests*, are never seen clearly.⁴ They appear as shadows through the light, and their silhouettes enact a form of digital shadow theater. The interrelation of visibility and invisibility in society is materialized here, uncovered on the nonexistent panes of glass windows dressed as screens.

The surface of these architectures, with their imaginary windows, functions as an elaborate form of mediation. Here we have a complex visual fabrication that, as the art historian Ewa Lajer-Burcharth notes, pushes boundaries and negotiates borders: because the migrants remain visually elusive, with the sounds of their voices audible but muffled, the installations convey an experience of subjective opacity in which not only the physical borders but also the contours of the inner life of citizens are at stake, and at risk.⁵ Going beyond the trope of



voyeurism, Wodiczko enacts an intersubjective play on the border between self and other, inner and outer space. As he forces us to confront who and what is inside or outside, he creates a window in which positions between outsider and insider may be not only mediated but even shifted around.

The surface of the installation's architecture renders possible not only the experience of the border but also a crossing of limits. This is a function of the density of the space. The fabric of this installation is thick, and deliberately never transparent. We are confronted with a material that is neither pure wall nor window, and yet has properties of both. On this particular canvas, a space of both conflation and displacement, the psychic space and the everyday space of people who are themselves displaced can reside. This can happen because of the added element of "screening" involved here. Subjective transparency is defied in favor of an opacity that reflects layers of projection. This surface is an imaginary architectural formation in which projections, both literally and metaphorically, can occur.

As we look closely at these walls, which act as windows, we can actually perceive them as screen surfaces, and this produces further effects of conflation and diffusion between forms.⁶ In order to see, we must navigate a surface that is visually configured as a white, dense material. A milky, textured substance appears to our senses, and, acting as a cover for the window-walls, it mediates the relation between seer and seen. In this sense, we perceive the materiality of projection, which is digitally configured to approach screen surface. Closer to a veil or curtain than to a pane of glass, this surface is the actual visual tissue of projection. Thus it is not just the function but also the consistency of these window-walls that is closely related to the fabric of the screen. Through the textural manifestation of the latticed image we can perceive—envisage—the support of the image and its representational medium. The projection screens, far from being invisible, are made palpable as projective matter. And thus, as we try to make out the foggy figures of the displaced people and hear their stories, we experience the mediatic quality of the screen as a veiled, and veiling, surface.

Wodiczko here expands on his long-standing practice of exposing the architecture of projection. In this artistic enterprise, the body of the person is consistently animated with and against the body of building forms. The space onto which the images are projected is never invisible but always rendered tangible. For example, in *The Tijuana Projection* (2001), the face of a woman mouthing her story is projected as if her skin were adhering to the spherical surface of the dome of the city's Centro Cultural. In *The Hiroshima Projection* (1999), it is the hands of survivors that speak, projected in close-up onto the moving surface of a river that appears to activate mnemonic flow. In this way we are made aware of the very texture of the surface onto which the image is projected. One might even say that the image is carved out of the material surface of the architecture that supports it, animates it, and moves it. The skin of the building becomes exposed, shown as a palpable, interstitial space of projection. A form of mediation, the architectural surface thus acts for Wodiczko as a partition; that is, it functions as a visible screen.

If You See Something . . . and *Guests* go even further than previous installations in dis-



playing the material of projection. As the surface is made physically present, it shows a pellicular quality. In these installations, screens can act as membranes. The fabric of the images is solidly permeable, and on the milky, veiled surface of projection the figures of the migrants concretely appear as a moving blur. As the figures move, their contours come in and out of focus, becoming more consistent as they approach the limit of the screen. The effect makes the screen feel like a tissue, a permeable, thin sheet. Such a screen appears to move like a membrane that is being stretched. Wodiczko plays ironically with this permeable materiality as he shows people trying to clean the impossibly foggy substance, and rain seems to fall at times, further veiling the surface. The surface is rendered as tensile as skin, even from the perspective of the viewers. Some visitors to the installation come up to the site of projection as if wishing the space could extend or stretch like a membrane. In turn, the migrants act as if the partition could bend or warp to create a passage, or as if it could be

4.3. Krzysztof Wodiczko, *If You See Something . . .*, 2005. Four projected video images with sound. Courtesy of the artist and Galerie Lelong, New York.

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visually traversed, like a veil. They push their bodies up to the surface and hold up pictures and objects as if wishing to push them through a layer of tissue. In many ways, this screen is shown to be elastic, flexible, and pliant.

Surface tension occurs here. This membrane is an actual screen: a site of partition in which migrants can negotiate status and story. In a way, one can imagine this membranelike surface acting as a protective layer for those figures, projected so they can affirm their existence and project their stories. But the membrane also still acts as a wall. There is substance, which is also a form of resistance, in this material of projection. As if to rebel against their status as shadows, the migrants push up against the partition as if against a real border. But let us not forget that the virtual architecture constructed by Wodiczko is also a window. In this capacity as aperture, the resilient surface can enable a passage. Possibilities of openings and a potential for exchange are sited on this composite and permeable screen that acts as a membrane.

The passage created in this installation mimics the actual form of surface tension that occurs on a film screen. Coated in the material fabric of projection, this is a space of cinematic traversal that includes spectatorial projections. As a visitor to this space, one is not safely positioned on the other side of the screen but rather stands on the border, for in order to perceive one must cross over and project oneself into the space of the other. Caught in the web of the installation, one cannot escape this mode of projection. The fabric of this screen is so absorbent that it absorbs the viewer too in its surface tension. To look is to feel this tension. One cannot simply stare at the surface. The tension of this tensile surface forces one to become engaged—to the point of wishing that borders might be crossed and contact might be made through the membrane, across the fabric of the screen. More than just a site of critical distance, this kind of screen is both resistant and embracing because it holds affects in its fabric. Its porous membrane enables the passage of empathy, which is itself a form of projection. In staging an epidermic form of exchange, this surface-membrane thus mediates the potential for relatedness that is inscribed in filmic projection.

The surface of this installation thus makes us tangibly aware of the many aspects of “screening.” And as the absorbent, luminous opacity leads us, visually and cognitively, to sift through the complex psychogeographic landscape of projection, a last layer of screening emerges. We sense the memory of film come to the surface. This turn to cinema is even more evident in Wodiczko’s . . . *OUT OF HERE: The Veterans Project*, an installation shown at the Institute of Contemporary Art in Boston from November 2009 through March 2010. Here, one enters into a dark space in which dim light appears to come from rectangular industrial windows above. Again these windows exist only as projections on the walls, and again the projections are also dressed as screens, but here they no longer project figures. On this walled, windowed canvas of projection, the atmosphere seems serene. People are heard but not shown. The sky appears calm, and a soccer ball goes by. Then, as when film evokes an unseen horror, something terrible happens offscreen. We cannot see clearly and cannot grasp the information that hits us from all directions. The

destruction that is war assaults us sensorially. The tension is palpable. The windows finally break. The crack in the interior-exterior space that is the product of war and globalization is here, embodied in digital space.

The indexical quality of celluloid may no longer be with us but this new pellicular membrane is just as affectively tensile. It can still hold us in deeply articulated surface tension. And so as the shadow theater that is cinema is reconfigured and rematerialized architecturally, and the white cube of the gallery turns luminously dark, we are given back the absorbent, relational fabric of projection, displayed on yet another form of screen-membrane.

Absorbent Luminosity: Surface, Projection, Screen. As it reworks the architecture of projection, Wodiczko's cinematic installation keeps the language of film closely knit to architectural configurations. In doing so, this work resonates deeply with some contemporary turns in architecture, where the surface has also become a canvas of interesting projections. The phenomenon is vast, but what is relevant for our argument here is to note that the architectural surface has itself become a screen. I do not mean this literally, merely in terms of media walls, though these certainly play a role.⁷ I am rather interested in stressing that architecture has annexed the moving image on a play of material surface that involves the fabrication of transmissible membranes, in a fundamental rethinking of transparency and opacity, darkness and light, with respect to conditions of subjective absorption.

In a concrete way, a renewed architectural interest in experimenting with luminosity and translucency has led to the emergence of surface in a new light. Terence Riley, who curated the landmark exhibition *Light Construction* at the Museum of Modern Art in 1995, clearly showed this turn to surface luminosity as a space that exists between transparency and opaqueness and emphasized "the tension between the viewer and object implied by the use of the architectural façade as a veiling membrane."⁸ The diverse projects represented in the show, by architects ranging from Herzog & de Meuron to Steven Holl, span a range of efforts to reconfigure the notion of surface and its material condition, a project that still endures. There appears to be a widespread "superficial" movement engaged in uncovering the strata and thickness of surface, and in creating deep, textured, layered surfaces. In this sense, this is an impulse that connects the visual arts to architecture on the translucent ground of screened images.

An interrelation of surfaces is emerging in visual fabrication, and this often resides in an aesthetic of textural, minimal simplicity that contains conceptual material complexity. In this regard, the reconfiguration of wall, window, and screen activated in the installation works that we are analyzing finds correspondence in architectural work such as that of Kazuyo Sejima and her Tokyo-based firm SANAA, founded together with Ryue Nishizawa. Think of the Glass Pavilion at the Toledo Museum of Art (2006), for which SANAA created a wall that had the density of thin membranes. The curved layers of glass make for a

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4.4. Kazuyo Sejima + Ryue Nishizawa/
SANAA, Glass Pavilion at the Toledo
Museum of Art, Toledo, Ohio, 2006.
© SANAA. Courtesy of SANAA.

thickness of volumes that borders on a sense of visual opacity. This is an ambiguous space of translucency, neither clearly transparent nor fully opaque. Here, too, as in the installations we have described, transparency is ultimately defied in favor of the creation of a membrane that enables layers of passage, which are not only physical but also redolent of projective effects. In fact, as architectural historian Eve Blau shows in her sustained analysis of tension in transparency, this glass pavilion creates a spatial feeling and a time-thickened sense, and in this atmosphere the visitor can be absorbed and projected.⁹ Such space is relational, in the sense implied by Wodiczko's installations. Furthermore, the kind of translucent membrane engaged by this architectural surface can also be understood to mediate a projection, and it is closely linked to the layers of experience of cinematic projection that we have been discussing. This too is a surface that generates a form of "screening" space that is projective and durational and in which the distance between inside and outside, object and subject, is reconfigured as a passage.

Surface (Self) Reflections: Canvas, Mirror, Screen. This kind of surface tension, which is an opaque effect of screening and of the layering of time and space, is also



found in artworks that engage the support of the image. This is the gray area that Gerhard Richter works in *Six Gray Mirrors* (2003), where the process of surface encounters is made palpable in exemplary ways. In this translucent installation at Dia:Beacon, six large, gray, opaque glass surfaces are presented for view. Made of reflective enamel material, these colored mirrors transparently incorporate three decades of the artist's production of gray paintings on canvas, as they fuse pigment onto the back of the glass.¹⁰

The reflective panels are projected from the wall on cantilevered supports in such a way as to defy any analogy to pure window or mere mirror, although they reflect the space that they are placed within, including the large rectangular industrial windows set high on the walls around the room. As in Wodiczko's work, we are presented with a geometry that engages glass, window, wall, canvas, and screen fabric, and fundamentally shifts the terms of the use of these mediums by conflating their qualities on the surface. This is a composite architecture that engages all these different forms on its planar shape, and thus invokes the

4.5. Gerhard Richter, *Six Gray Mirrors*
No. 884/1-6, 2003. Installation view,
Dia:Beacon, Riggio Galleries, Beacon, New
York. Photo: Richard Barnes. Courtesy
of Dia Art Foundation, New York.

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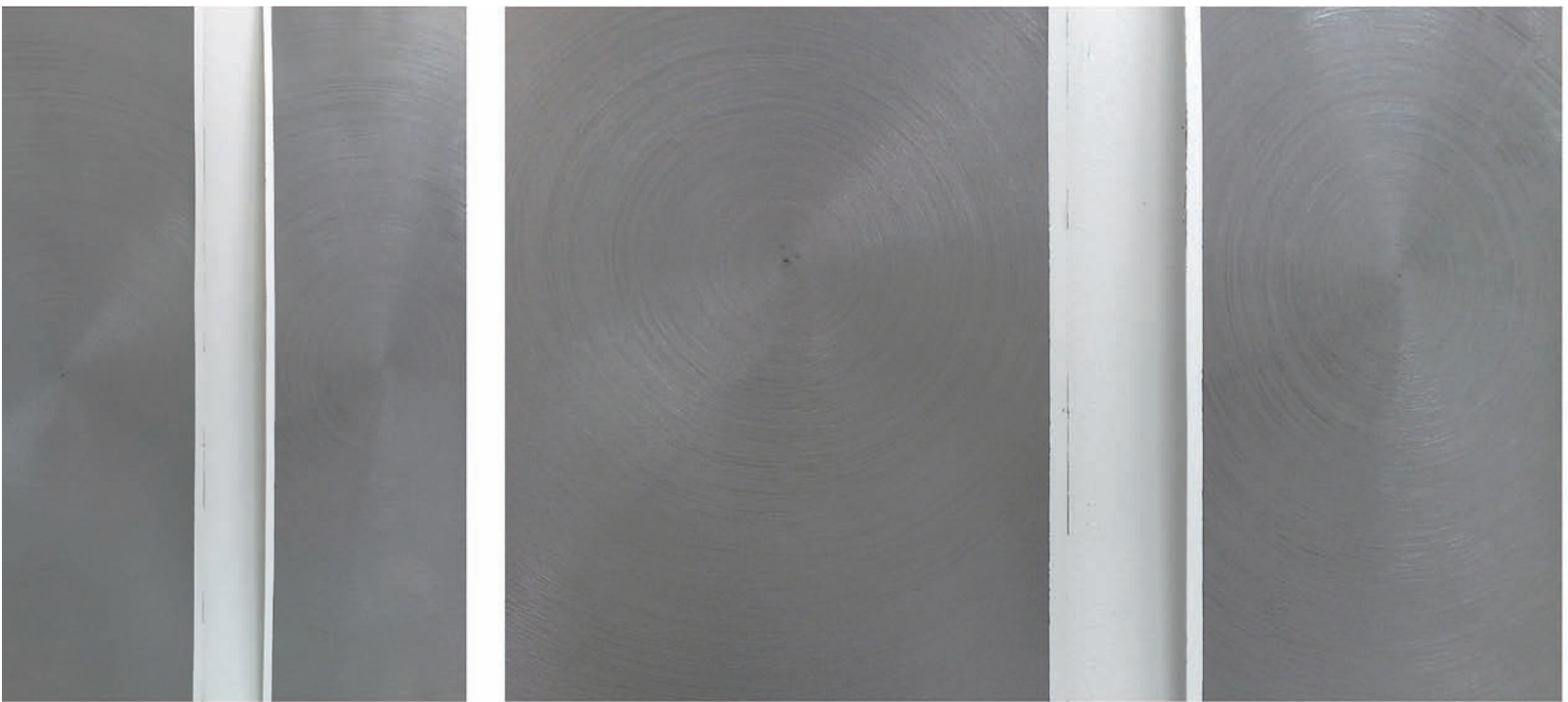


4.6. Sophie Tottie, sketches for *White Lines* (*wubg.tds*), 2010. Oil, gesso, paper, 37 ⁵/₈ × 12 in. each (details). Photo: Marcus Schneider, Sophie Tottie. Courtesy of the artist.

language of painting, architecture, photography, and film and fuses their treatment of the surface. Furthermore, with Richter, the effect of the cantilevered projection of the plane enhances the relationship between architecture and sculpture that is built into the surface. Built in such a conflated way, this luminous surface is quite voluminous and deep.

Both a reflective and a projective canvas, the thick surface of Richter's work incorporates us, the viewers, and does so in time as both the planes and our position shift. The composite architecture of the installation is built in a way that not only refracts but also filters the environment. There is an effect of "weathering" built into the work, which changes with time. The panels can be tilted at various angles, and depending on the time of day or the weather condition the effect of the work is different for the observers reflected—or rather, projected—into the architecture of the artwork.

In this installation, radiance and opacity meet in an atmospheric form of projection. Here too we have effects of absorbent opacity, close to those of the layered surfaces and the fabric of veiling we encountered earlier. Pure transparency is again defied in this glass architecture, but this time in a different shade of gray. On this surface we can experience the ambiguity of penumbra, the obscurity of somber shades, and a range of crepuscular hues. Ultimately, the color of the light here is rather dark, as it is in Matisse's painting *French Window at Collioure* (1914), an almost abstract canvas that pulls you into the darkness filtered by the window opening it depicts. In some way then, this particular surface-effect of absorbent opacity is akin to the kind of perceptual "blinding" that art historian Yve-Alain



Bois describes as an effect of perceptual slowness.¹¹ In order to actually see, we must slow down and adjust our gaze over time, and, in the process, we must let diffusion, dissolution, and decentering come to the surface. In such a way, we can come to experience the gray zone that is the darkness of light.

Environmental Projections: Canvas, Window, Screen. Understood in this way, the sensing of the surface cannot be separated from the experience of the self as a subject of perception, who becomes absorbed in time in a space of projection in which the material of light is activated on a surface. To further this point, it is important to recall that, historically, the experience of light on canvas created a space in which the observer, no longer capable of existing outside the space of observation, actually became incorporated into it. Art historian Jonathan Crary theorizes this important passage when he speaks of the effects of light in the paintings of Turner. As he puts it, “The distance between subject and object, that is, between a viewer and the world, collapses in the physical inscription of the sun onto the body,” and thus “the lived body of the spectator and the exterior world of physical events are one indivisible field.”¹² When experienced as mediated on a surface, the sensory quality of light opens up this potential space, which is able to incorporate subjectivity, holding its inscription and projections in space. In this sense, one could argue that the surface of the canvas can act as a screen. It can act, that is, as an actual projective surface

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4.7. Luisa Lambri, *Untitled (Barragan House, #06)*, 2005. Laserchrome print, 33 7/8 × 37 3/4 in. © Barragan Foundation, Switzerland. Courtesy of the artist and Luhring Augustine, New York.

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onto which an experience of close relations between subject and object is inscribed, in a way that overcomes divisions between outside and inside, inward and outward.

As a pictorial phenomenon, this effect of absorption in the surface is returned to us in contemporary works that strive to hold light on surface and in this way create textural materiality in minimal forms. Such is the case for the painter Sophie Tottie. She has experimented with capturing light on canvas in a series of paintings entitled *R.W.B.* and *G.R.S./B.R.Y.* from 2009, followed by *White Lines (wubg.tds)*, a series of gray paintings from 2010. Tottie's gray paintings produce an effect of absorbent opacity that, as with Richter, issues from sustained observation, the mobility of the observing subject, and the projection of temporality that

is built into the work. In her gray paintings, the reflection of light is held in the physical brushstrokes that strive to capture and retain the physicality and the texture of light. Tottie makes the surface of the painting as radiant as a screen, defying immediate illumination in favor of a projection of duration. The effect of the work changes a great deal over time depending on the existing light in the environment and the position of the observer. The texture of this luminous surface is sensitive to shifting weather conditions, which, in turn, become absorbed on the surface. On these canvases, as on the fabric of the screen, the experience of light as it is mediated on a surface becomes an environmental experience that incorporates the movement of observation and the sensing of time as an atmosphere.

When encountering textures of light and fading shadows, whether reflected on canvas or on screen fabrics, the observer is thus enveloped inside a layered sensory experience of ambience: an absorption in the temporal effects of environmental surfaces. The sensing of a luminous surface produces such an environmental tension, for it holds us to the rhythm and passage of time in space. This effect can also be seen in the luminous photographs of Luisa Lambri, who constructs the depth of architectural surfaces with minimalist elegance and care for the atmosphere of a place.¹³ Working in the register of architectural photography, pioneered with particular conceptual rigor by Candida Höfer, Lambri activates the architectural surface with light. But departing from Höfer, her abstracted spaces strive to include inhabitation in the absence of people. In this sense, her approach is not unlike that of the evocative architectural picturing of James Casebere, who for the last thirty years has been building models of places and photographing them, using light to suggest an atmospheric, mnemonic sense of narrative for the site.¹⁴ Casebere's luminous abstract spaces cinematically evoke previous and potential events, and, in its own way, Lambri's treatment of architecture also constructs such a projective surface, with the possibility for viewers to be fictionally projected in the site.

A series of photographs from 2005, *Untitled (Barragan House)*, is particularly significant because in it Lambri tackles the extraordinary work of Luis Barragán, the Mexican architect for whom light was an architecture and who created his own brand of modernism by building with light surfaces and sculpting with vivid color.¹⁵ Focusing on a window of Barragán's house in Mexico City, Lambri creates a sequence of experiential sensations of the intensity of the space. In this series, the frame of the photograph incorporates the frame of the window, and the language of photography meets that of architecture in the creation of a conflated surface. Using the shutters as partitions, Lambri renders the environmental feeling of observing light filtering into the space of the house. Partially obscuring the frame, the shutters furthermore give volume to the flat photographic surface, which appears to comprise different and moving planes. In this representation of windows, the transparency of the glass is defied in favor of an articulated surface in which light reflectively transpires in textural ways. As observers of this series, we sense the passage of time on a surface that screens the light and renders atmosphere, and we are included in the living fabric of Barragán's space. In the end, as the series progresses, the image becomes almost abstract, turning into a mere

4.8. Rudolf Stingel, *Untitled*, 1994. Oil and enamel on canvas, 12 × 12 ft. © Rudolf Stingel. Collection of the artist. Photo: D. James Dee. Courtesy of Paula Cooper Gallery, New York.

white texture. Represented here is an enveloping luminous substance, a fibrous canvas of light. No longer a window, this aperture is a screen. It is a fabric of projections.

Pliant Textures. As it emerges here, the transitive passage between canvas, wall, and screen is an aesthetic phenomenon engaged in a textural reconfiguration of surface that is, at some level, intrinsically architectural. This aspect of the contemporary reworking of the surface finds its own expression in the art of Rudolf Stingel, which, as Chrissie Iles notes, is characterized by surface tension. Stingel creates reflective surfaces that can be inscribed by the viewers, remakes tapestries in the form of canvases, and builds works in which the horizontality of wall and the verticality of floor are challenged as the entire space becomes a canvas.¹⁶ For Stingel, walls not only can turn into floors but can mutate into mirrors, and they can become screens as well. In an aesthetic that might be called “minimal Baroque,” surfaces are highlighted and conflated. Stingel refashions the effects of décor, decoration, and ornament and reconfigures their positions in space, making them resurface as substantial planes of visual expression and essential fabrics of the visual.

In its multiform architectural expressions, Stingel’s work always shows a tensility in the surface that is textural and, at times, even atmospheric. For this artist, surface tension includes a textured treatment of luminosity that is elaborately fabricated on canvas. In a series of large paintings from the early 1990s, *Untitled*, Stingel sought to capture luminosity in ways that are not optical but rather haptic, inventively using oil and enamel on canvas. He applied layers of colored pigment to the canvas and spray-painted a coating of silver through the porous, netted surface of a sheet of tulle, which was used as yet another layer of fabric in the artwork. The tulle was then peeled away, as if it were skin, but it remained present as a textural trace on the painting. The effect of the work is subtle, offering a complex textural manifestation that is sensuously tactile. As Stingel seductively reworks the actual material of canvas and makes us aware of the layers and porosity of its surface materiality, the painting itself reads as an actual fabric. The tension held by the canvas is projected in its layered architecture, and the surface shows the fabric of this fabrication. In encountering such a surface, a new minimalism of closeness rather than distance can be experienced, for the intimate fabric of the work draws the beholder in with the simple, elegant textuality of its visual pattern.

Curtained Spaces. Architected in planes akin to layers of cloth, the surface emerges as an elaborate form of textural fabrication, the envelope of a material mediation that does not exclude intimacy. To further experience this effect of closeness in the conflated surface as it is built across canvas, wall, and screen, think of how the artist Do-Ho Suh reworks the surface, transforming the material of sculpture and architecture into cloth.¹⁷ This Korean artist, who lives in New York, is known for having made exact replicas of his homes in Seoul



and in New York, casting them in fabric. *348 West 22nd St., Apt. A, New York, NY 10011, USA* (2000), for example, is a tentlike structure, with every element made of nylon cloth through which one can see. Here, tectonics is defined as the architectural surface comes close to being a permeable canvas, or even a curtain. Walls, doors, and windows are made of a light, translucent material as a way to enable viewers to access a psychic geography profoundly marked by dislocation. As the scrims transform the relation between inside and outside, turning architecture inside out, they become a form of projection of geopsychic displacement, and the physical marker of existence in between cultures.

This particular fabrication, in which scrim-walls project a hybrid cultural geography, becomes even more evident in *Blueprint*, the installation Do-Ho Suh produced in collaboration with the Seoul-based studio Suh Architects for the 2010 Venice Architecture Biennale. The installation is twofold. Floating in suspension on top, a translucent fabric refashions the actual volumes of the townhouse in New York where Suh now resides, with verticality turned horizontal. Below, on the floor, a laminate surface, a shadow of the fabrication above, features faint images of the façade of the New York townhouse, the artist's former home in Korea, and a Venetian villa, creating a composite geography. A projection of conflated cultural configurations takes place in the texture of this work. On these planes we can experience the intimate space of dislocation through material surfaces whose conflated properties act as screens of multiple cartographies. In this architecture of dwelling, a foldable structure as pliant as curtains, the hybrid effect of cultural mobility is intimately fashioned in material portability.

Envelope, Curtain, Screen. The translucent depth of Do-Ho Suh's work in pliant fabrics leads us to reflect further on how deeply the textural aspect of surface tension, as manifested in contemporary art, resonates with the history of surface as a material site for architectural reconfiguration. The history of modern experimentation that links the pliable plane to textile in architecture owes much to the Bauhaus.¹⁸ As the art historian T'ai Smith has shown, the study of cloth and weaving enabled the Bauhaus to overcome the limits of opticality and to explore tactility and materiality.¹⁹ A sartorial understanding of space was advanced by women weavers such as Otti Berger, who wrote of "fabrics in space" in 1930 as she considered "the tactile in cloth" and thus pioneered the sense of textile in the design of haptic spatiality.²⁰ In both her practice and her writings, Anni Albers also theoretically pursued the relation between surface and textile, and inscribed mobility on this plane.²¹ She insisted that there is a fundamental relationship between textile, mobilization, and cultural transit, putting forth ideas that we have observed at work texturally in contemporary times, as exemplarily activated on the surface of Do-Ho Suh's installations.

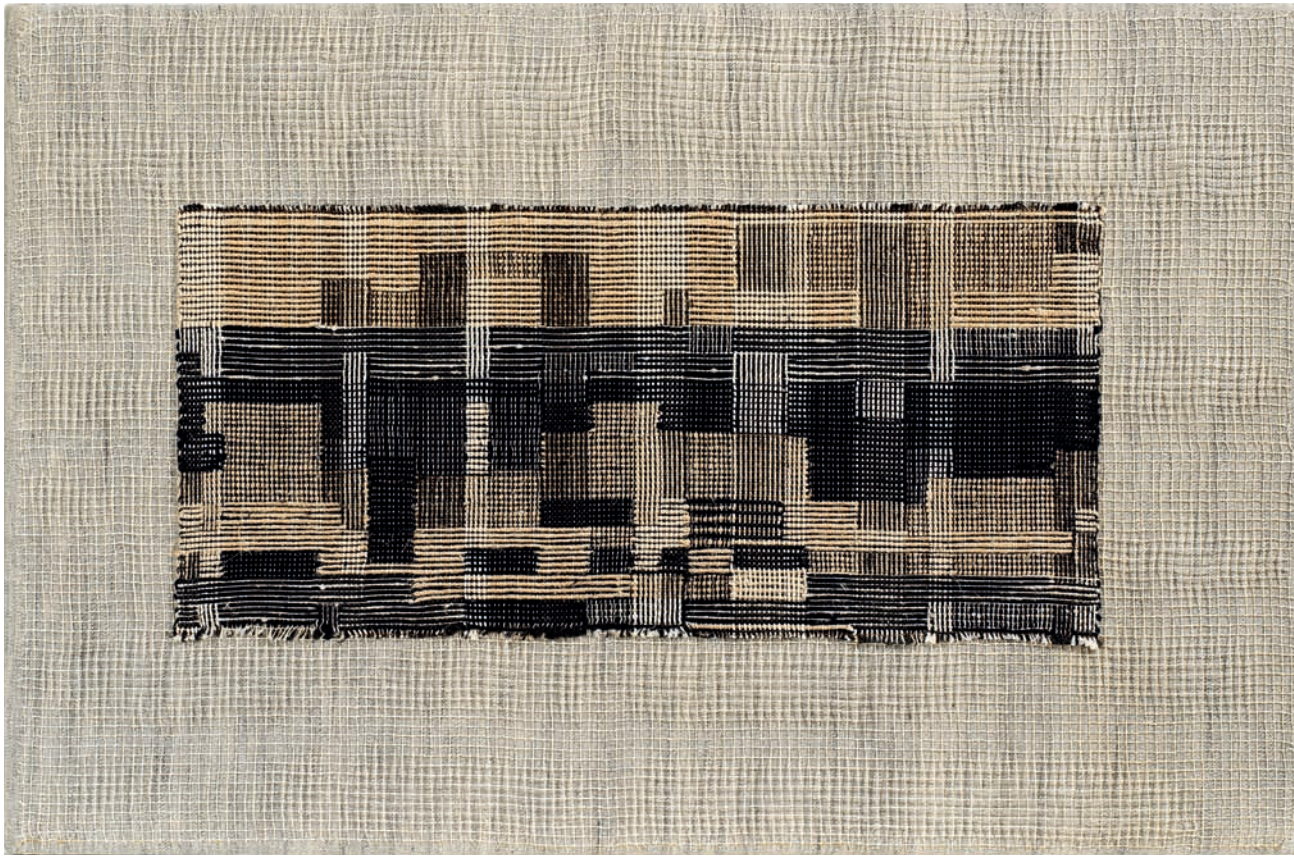
In her essay "The Pliable Plane: Textiles in Architecture," written in 1957, Albers suggested thinking of the processes of building and weaving as related rather than antithetical modes, using an argument that goes beyond even Gottfried Semper's notion that architecture orig-



4.9. Do-Ho Suh, *Blueprint*, 2010. Installation view, Venice Biennale 2010, 12th International Architecture

Exhibition. Polyester fabric, laminated panel, 43 ft. 7 ⁵/₈ in. × 20 ft. 10 in. × 11 ft. ⁵/₈ in. © Do-Ho Suh

and Suh Architects. Photo: Stefano Graziani. Courtesy of Do-Ho Suh and Suh Architects.



4.10. Anni Albers, *City*, 1949. Linen and cotton pictorial weaving, 17 1/2 x 26 1/2 in. © 2011 The Josef and Anni Albers Foundation/Artists Rights Society, New York. Courtesy of the Josef and Anni Albers Foundation.

inates in textile.²² She dwelled on the forms of mobility that the lightness and pliability of cloth can afford, and connected architecture and clothing on this plane. “When we revert to nomadism,” she wrote, “as travelers, we are open to textile behavior.”²³ She understood the movable, portable, adaptable, transformative quality of fabric, and the moving sensibility that it can culturally convey. Albers furthermore called for the affirmation of touch, for “the soft play of folds, and the luster or fuzz of fiber.”²⁴ In her essay “Tactile Sensibility,” from 1965, she pledged that we “will make of our surfaces textile surfaces.”²⁵ The word “textural” makes a substantial appearance in her writing, describing something apparent on the surface, a component of what she calls a “surface play.”²⁶

As she described “the character of mobility in our fabrics,” Albers made an aesthetic out of material surfaces that were considered neither architecture nor worthy of aesthetic consideration.²⁷ She was interested in material objects that “can be lifted, folded, carried, storied away, and exchanged easily” and claimed that “the very fact of mobility makes them the carrier of extra aesthetic value.”²⁸ Her pioneering interest in surface included the texture of fabric walls, veil-like fabric panels, and curtains, for they can be “drawn open and closed, letting in light or shutting it out, thereby changing dramatically the appearance of

a room.”²⁹ By now, this textural approach to the surface is less marginal and marginalized. As we consider the ways in which contemporary architects such as Toshiko Mori are interested in sensory fabrics and “extreme textile,” we can appreciate how far the legacy of Albers has extended.³⁰

Cloth has gained acceptance in architecture. In particular, curtains, once relegated to interior décor, have come out into the open, becoming central to the architectural redefinition of boundary and envelope.³¹ We can see this activated in particular in the work of Petra Blaisse and her studio Inside Outside, which was responsible for designing curtains for SANAA’s Glass Pavilion at the Toledo Museum of Art, described earlier.³² Composed of tissues and membranes, filaments and scrims, Blaisse’s curtained universe is a moving space of fabric and matter that is activated by light. The reflective material of her curtains reminds us of the surface of the screen, itself a material that is acted upon and activated in luminous ways. In a way, then, Blaisse’s screen-curtains return us not only to Anni Albers but also to Loïe Fuller’s dance of veils as it transformed into the electric fabric of cinema. In their textural ability to convey the art of projection, the transfer between inside and outside, and the surface play of atmosphere and mood, these curtains join with film’s own moving space of luminous theatricality and projection.

Envelopes of Surface Materiality. As architecture rethinks the distinctions between structure and ornament, function and décor, form and façade, the surface no longer has the status of decorative element but becomes an entity in itself. In contemporary times, surface turns into actual architecture. In construction, it exerts great seduction as a material site of inventive fabrication. As David Leatherbarrow and Mohsen Mostafavi put it in their book *Surface Architecture*, “Once the skin of the building became independent of its structure, it could just as well hang like a curtain or clothing.”³³ Going far beyond the notion of a “curtain wall,” the potential elasticity of the skin of a building has become the focus of an expanded architectural experimentation of texture. The envelope is dwelt on as a tactile fabric, and, as Farshid Moussavi and Michael Kubo show in *The Function of Ornament*, the surface becomes “weighted, deep, differentiated, tartan, alternating, camouflaged, tonal, gradated, textured, branded, serial.”³⁴ When worked on as an essential texture of visual fabrication, the surface is treated as a pliable fabric of communication.

In dressing the surface in this way, architecture joins the conceptual work of tailoring and recalls the refashioning of materiality that we have observed in visual art. This new “superficiality” is a fundamental issue for architecture, for, in its function as cloth, the surface is a fabric that mediates important material relations. With the aid of digital design, as architectural historian Antoine Picon argues, we not only see an emphasis on surface but also a mediatic refashioning, because, as exemplarily expressed in the work of Herzog & de Meuron, the reworking of ornament and envelope is not just a redressing of materials.³⁵ This is a matter of form that can affect structure. When the shift to the digital becomes a

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field of relations, engaging a flexibility that empowers the body, as the new-media scholar Mark Hansen proposes, it can constitute a defining material cultural shift of our time, and this is bound to affect the design of architecture.³⁶

The surface, in my view, is poised to be at the center of this process of rematerialization insofar as it is constituted, by its very nature, as an architectural partition. The surface is a form of dwelling that engages mediation between subjects and with objects, and in this sense, it can become a site of screening and projection. As in visual art, in architecture the material of surface becomes the site of expression of a new materiality as the surface is texturally reconfigured to hold different forms of material relation and convey their transformation. A material manifestation of the negotiation of architectural space, surface has not only become structure but can restructure our sense of contact to the environment. Like a new form of skin, a surface condition can activate new relations, in the sense of different forms of relatedness. In its function as cloth, the architectural surface can also mediate permeability between inside and outside. As the architectural curtain reworks interior and exterior, inner and outer space, it does so not only physically but also imaginatively. This process can lead to an incorporation of emotion into the landscape of surface interaction. After all, a surface condition creates sensitivity to the skin of things, and this kind of sensory interaction includes atmosphere and mood. In some way, then, the permeable envelope of the surface can create an expansion of the sensorium and a renewed access to the life of interiority as well as extend the reach of affect. In all these ways, this pervasive surface condition signals a substantial refashioning of materiality. Here, in surface tension, we can sense a profound cultural transformation as modes of surface encounters and connectivity take place in this theater of surface.

Screens: The Theater of Surface. As the surface has acquired its own theatricality and performativity, it is not surprising that it would return to the stage in more luminous forms to refashion theatrical space. Think of Alice Tully Hall in New York's Lincoln Center for the Performing Arts, as refurbished by Diller Scofidio + Renfro. Curtained with a thin veneer of wood, the interior walls of the auditorium are as light as curtains and become as luminous as screens. As light transpires from behind the thin layer of their material surface, it creates atmosphere and mood throughout the auditorium. The pinkish light emerges through the surface of the walls, like perspiration through skin, giving the impression that the walls are blushing. In such a way, the surface shows its tangible potential to become theatrically atmospheric.

When light is filtered outward in this way, it creates a textural surface that takes on several performative qualities. Activated by atmospheric translucency, wall, curtain, and screen take on similar characteristics, becoming conflated spaces of performance. A particularly effective example of this transfer on the surface can be found in *MetaFoil* (2008), the stage curtain designed by the artist Pae White for the auditorium of the Oslo Opera



House. When seen against the dark, timbered walls of the auditorium, designed by the Norwegian architectural firm Snøhetta, this curtain, composed in different shades of gray, changes fantastically. Seen and touched up close, the fabric is flat. But when activated by the light in the auditorium, and perceived from a spectatorial position, the bidimensional plane of the textile is transformed into a plastic, three-dimensional material. The effect is made possible by a digital twist to traditional forms of weaving: White worked with digital images of aluminum foil and transferred them to a computer-driven loom. The resulting metallic fabric has the texture of tapestry, and this “feel” of the fabric becomes enhanced by luminous effects. The stage curtain creates an actual foil when lit, offering the illusion of depth and the sensation of volume. Shifts of scale and pattern appear on the reflective surface, which ends up projecting shades of plasticity and tones of movement.

When one sits in the audience of this theater and looks straight ahead at this illuminated geometry, there can be no doubt that the curtain is a screen. White’s stage curtain,

4.11. Pae White, *MetaFoil*, 2008. Cotton, wool, polyester, and Trevira, 35 ft. 117/8 in. × 94 ft. 113/4 in. Stage curtain for the Oslo Opera House theater. Photo: Erik Berg. Courtesy of the artist, the Norwegian National Opera and Ballet, Public Art Norway, and neugerriemschneider, Berlin.

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in fact, not only looks like a screen but acts like one. Represented here is one of the most fundamental aspects of cinema: the fabric quality of the screen. This stage curtain calls attention to the textile ability exhibited by the filmic screen and makes us reflect further on its textural potentiality. In a way, it shows how film can act like a curtain, or even like a vertical carpet, as Philippe-Alain Michaud, speaking of carpets and cinema, aptly proposes.³⁷ Indeed, film is a form of tapestry. But its tapestry work extends further than the vision of carpets because it goes beyond figuration, narrative assemblage, and textual weave. The textural work of the moving image is not only figurative or textual, for it begins with, and on, the white surface of the screen. It is, in its most basic form, a matter of fabric.

As in Pae White's stage curtain, the cinematic screen is a luminous, reflective surface that refracts not only light but motion. Its reflective capacity extends to shifts in size and scale. This is a textured, volumetric space that, when luminously activated, can also create an illusion of depth. The flatness of textile is defied and transformed not only into depth of field but also into volume, as various planes and shifting shapes appear on its surface. On the screen, the surface is given body. It becomes a form of sculptural, three-dimensional space in which bodies of light can haptically materialize in motion. In this sense, there is a fundamentally ornamental structure in filmic space. This is a place of textural moving forms, where surfaces that are radiantly activated turn into architectures of material opacity and plastic materiality. In film, as environments and atmospheres are projected on a surface, the surface itself becomes an environment. The moving image is, ultimately, a movement of surfaces. This is not surprising, for the meaning of projection is rooted in something cast on surface. And this includes the spectators, for on the fabric of the screen, it is us who experience an actual "projection" in this movement of surfaces.

Landscapes of Pliable Matter. Whether displayed on Pae White's curtain-screen or on the film screen, the surface is neither flat nor two-dimensional but—against the grain of geometry—conveys volumes of cultural motion and aesthetic plasticity. In order to theorize this dimensional surface movement, it has been important to thread it through different material expressions. To this end, I close with another surface encounter in the visual arts, as offered by the elegant art of Tara Donovan. This artist starts with everyday objects—plastic cups, straws, Scotch tape, pencils, pins, toothpicks—obsessively arranging them in seemingly infinite series to make large-scale installations. The walls or floors of the installations become landscapes populated by these forms, which, unfolding in apparent replication, are perceived as both organic and inorganic. Donovan's material surfaces evoke a vast range of topographies, from the scientific exploration of inner forms to the aerial mapping of cityscapes. Her pliant, latticed matrixes extend from geologic to biologic to nano scales, as if capturing the volume of their generative processes. Transporting us from exterior to interior geography, they cover the range of our cellular life.



4.12. Tara Donovan, *Haze*, 2005. Installation view, *Tara Donovan*, Institute of Contemporary Art, Boston, October 10, 2008–January 4, 2009. Translucent plastic drinking straws, dimensions variable. Photo: Dennis Cowley. © Tara Donovan. Courtesy of Pace Gallery, New York.

This plastic surface effect is enhanced by the artist's frequent use of translucent materials: Elmer's glue, in *Strata* (2000–2001); Scotch tape, in *Nebulous* (2002); monofilament line, in *Lure* (2004). Her more recent use of materials such as Mylar and polyester film further enhances the capacity of the surfaces to absorb, reflect, refract, and diffuse light. *Untitled (Mylar Tape)*, from 2007, for example, has the three-dimensional sense of a shimmering wallpaper bas-relief that, in a play of surface displacement between wall and ceiling, becomes the decorative form of a starry constellation. The effect is of an opaque absorption in luminosity that ambiguously shifts. Haze is how it can be described, as in the title of one of Donovan's atmospheric installations. In *Haze* (2005), thousands of translucent plastic drinking straws are irregularly piled onto one another, their original, ordinary form transformed as they converge into a vertical plane and are morphed into an abstract, translucent, volumetric surface. Seductive to the touch, this minimally constructed, elegantly textured plane becomes a wall of filtered, reflected light—a screen of surface materiality.

Here we sense a reinterpretation of earlier luminous spatial works, as we do in Tony Feher's exhibition *Next On Line* (2011), in which clear vinyl tubes filled with colored water and hung from walls or ceilings transform themselves and the space into luminous arabesque fabrics. As in Feher's installations, the sensation of space Donovan devises strongly recalls the experience of being in the light spaces Robert Irwin has created since the 1960s, with which we opened our investigation of surface. But it is as if Irwin's landscape is subjected here to another phenomenological transformation, and a different range of experiential phenomena. This is Irwin filtered through the morphology of the digital age. The translucent surfaces Donovan activates respond to the technological remapping of surfaces in our era, a time in which, as we have argued, surface is being fundamentally redefined. As art historian David Joselit puts it, "For artists steeped in an electronic image world . . . the 'beyond' is articulated as a 'beside.' . . . There is an implosion of space within the surface itself, where information flows are internally segmented or regulated."³⁸ In a way, Donovan's form of abstraction responds to this transformation of surface into network. This is a cellular cartography, which indeed exhibits the material of electronic, molecular, neural, or even viral networks. But her landscape is not constituted as a "beside," and this surface does not do away with the articulation of a space between inside and outside; rather it redefines its borders through different forms of connectivity.

With respect to this redefinition of sites, the digital space represented by Donovan is, in fact, constituted as a connective architecture. The superficial materiality exhibited by this visual artist resonates most closely with contemporary architectural experimentation, which is itself in dialogue with scientific and technological languages and deeply fascinated by their matrixes. One can read Donovan's opaque translucency in the light of such field relations and at the same time notice in her work a particular fashion of digital formalism that is also manifested in architecture. In fact, as we have noted, following an interest in Gilles Deleuze's dynamic, unfolding, continuous, and multiple universe,

architectural design has pursued a formal research that strives to render the fluid form of this materiality. Deleuze's pliant conception of the fold is particularly consonant with the dynamic systems put in place by contemporary technological and scientific developments, and it follows that the architectural surface has embraced this envelope, hosting a field of forces in motion. As we approach the constitutive shape of Donovan's universe in light of this work, we can see the connective thread come to the surface. The infinite, folding curves of her superficial universe appear very close in shape to those produced today by digital architectural design, which they strongly resemble, even in physical appearance. Donovan's reworking of the surface is closely aligned with the outcome of digital architecture: it shares not only its shapes but, what is more important, its fundamental interest in materials, not as things per se but as a way of producing materiality. In Donovan's universe, there is not only a representation of digital universes but also a manifestation of how the digital can reinvent a surface condition that is a form of materiality.

This particular form of digitally inflected design is invested in redefining the folds of space, which include the borders of connectivity between interior and exterior as they are manifested on the surface. Donovan reworks this space "in between," as is evident in one of her most accomplished installations, *Untitled*, which opened at the Institute of Contemporary Art in Boston in 2008 and creates a dialogue with the architecture of the building, designed again by Diller Scofidio + Renfro. A long rectangular aperture is cut into the wall that faces the large glass window-façade of the museum, which opens onto a spectacular sea view. Inside this aperture, which can be seen from both sides, there are infinite folds composed of thousands of sheets of polyester film, which together create a thick stratum of translucent material. The effect is reminiscent of light filtered through colored stained glass in Gothic architecture, and it is suggestive of how this may be an early example of what makes projection possible. With Donovan's aperture, we face an elaborate, kaleidoscopic universe of opaque material luminosity. This aperture is not a window but a screen. A material of display, it does not simply refract the light but fully screens it. As the illuminated rectangular shape of the display case refashions the luminous geometry of the screen, it also reminds us of its exhibitionary fabric. This screen is a medium that acts as a refracting canvas and a textured wallpaper. Shaped like a dimensional painting of light, this is an absorbing panoramic architecture. A digital reinterpretation of the visual architecture that generated the medium of cinema, this work is also time-based. Depending on the time of the day or the darkness of the night, the featured view changes, and we experience it differently. This folding surface, which rests between interior and exterior, is sensitive to the extent of time, its infinite folds, and the effects of weathering. Not exactly a window or a canvas, and yet with the properties of both, this is a fabric of projection. Such work defies flatness and puts the surface into movement, as if it were remastering an actual process of screening. Hence, in the folds of this fabric, a reinvention of materiality takes place as the environmental geography of screen surfaces and their moving form of projection are refashioned in the shape of mediatic connections.



4.13. Tara Donovan, *Untitled*, 2008. Installation view, *Tara Donovan*, Institute of Contemporary Art, Boston, October 10, 2008-January 4, 2009. Polyester film, dimensions variable. Photo: Dennis Cowley. © Tara Donovan. Courtesy of Pace Gallery, New York.

Tensile Surfaces, Screen Fabrics. Whether the material is canvas, wall, or screen, surface tension has emerged as a central condition of contemporary visual art and architecture, signaling a refashioning of materiality and a reinscription of textural movement on our cultural screens. As we have threaded together material relations on the surface, we have observed a process of conflation between canvas, wall, and screen in renewed forms of projection. The surface of the medium is concretely turned into a membrane and substantially revitalized in stretchable, moving forms. No longer an ephemeral or marginal part of the work, the surface is pushed to the limit of its potentiality to become the actual core and structure of the work. In most of the works considered here, a reinterpretation of ornament and texture engages a renewed form of tactility in elegant visual ways. In an aesthetic of minimal simplicity, attention to material defines a surface condition that is an affirmation of materiality intended in the largest sense. As textural matter builds a dense plane of perceptual intersections between inside and outside, a thick, layered space of interactions between subject and object, interior and exterior, emerges in time. As pliable material, sensitive to environmental mutation and mobile subjectivity, this pliant surface shows itself capable of holding the folds of time and the inner structure of temporality. Insofar as it is a physical skin, it can also express the sensorium of affects, the sensations of mood, and the sensuality of atmosphere. It is in this sense that surface can be read as an architecture. Not only is it constituted as a space in itself; it is a maker of space. Furthermore, the surface has the character of architecture in the crucial sense that it is not flat. This surface is acted on, plastically activated, and sculpted. It is carefully dwelt on, articulated in planes that are mutable and fabricated as transformative fabric. Densely built up in this way, it is constructed as deeply tensile, in the sense that it also a landscape of projective motion and connectivity. Such a surface, far from being superficial, is indeed a sizable, moving entity: it is a space of real dimension, a site of intimacy that can, in turn, be inhabited. Which is to say, it is a real screen.

Layers and More Layers: Immersive Environments. In the end, please refold. Rewind back to the beginning, and fast-forward to 2010. The space of the Dia Center for the Arts in New York that was home to Robert Irwin's 1998 installation is by now closed. But the mode of this installation lives on as a mnemonic canvas in contemporary works that activate the movement of surface and refashion translucent minimalism in surface intimacy. Its way of refashioning the fabric of the screen also returns as an architecture, reinvented with a mediatic twist in the new media works shown in the same Chelsea art district.

Think of *Layers Mama Layers*, the 2010 installation by Pipilotti Rist, as a case in point that provides a bookend to this discourse.³⁹ Here, the space of the gallery is redefined by a series of cascading "sheets" that hang down from the ceiling, made of diaphanous fabric.

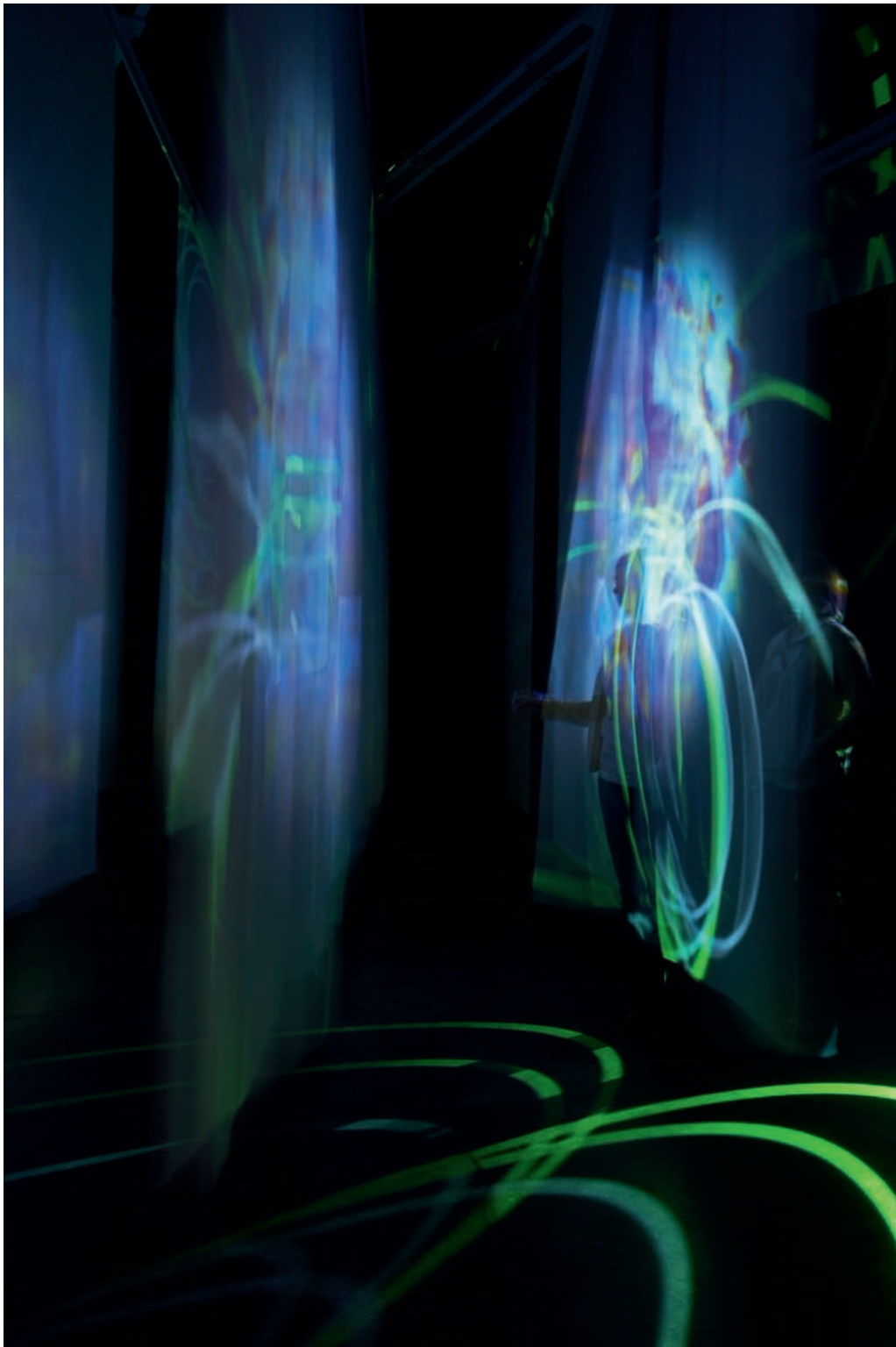
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The fabric is as thinly transparent as a veil, and, like a curtain, it reflects and absorbs light. This translucent gray fabric creates a layered atmosphere for the site and becomes the canvas for multiple projections. On two sides of the walls are video projectors that feed images, respectively, of a pastoral landscape dotted with sheep and an abstract landscape of luminous animations. The images appear on the fabric, which, effectively, becomes a screen.

Rist's installation makes palpable how the fabric of the screen has endured but at the same time changed geometry. No longer held down by a frame or to a frame, this screen is definitively not a window. Or rather it is no longer a singular window. It incorporates the changes of the digital age in the form of screening, a process that also involves multiplied and multiplying windows. More specifically, it renders the ever-present environmental screen-effect within which we now live. We no longer face or confront a screen only frontally but are rather immersed in an environment of screens. We move within a continuous world of projections that extend from the exterior walls of the architectures of our cities all the way to our homes and offices, and to the screen extensions constantly attached to the palms of our hands. On these portable screens tactility is rekindled, as touch is digitally reinscribed on pads. Haptically experienced as a texture, and even as a membrane, the fabric of the screen has become a canvas of refashioned materiality, while screen surface extends to an entire screen environment that itself becomes experienced as a surrounding membrane.

Rist's installation is interesting for the way that it architects a fluid, haptic world of surround screens in which one can experience both similarity to and difference from the luminous screen space created by Robert Irwin. The changes that have occurred in between these two moments in the very architecture of screening are reflected in the way visitors experience this installation. As a visitor to *Layers Mama Layers*, one becomes an integral part of a pervasive screen environment in which it is no longer preferable or even possible to be positioned in front of the work. As spectators experience projection by entering into layers of scrims, their own figures are reflected and projected back into the work. The corporeal presence of the viewers in the midst of these projections thus ends up itself screened through the veils of the installation. With the complete collapse of frontality and distance also comes a less reverent and more interactive relationship to the work. As one walks into the layers of hanging scrims, one can not only move freely through and pause within the space but also play with the scrims, using one's own screen to interact with the other screen layers. Visitors appear encouraged by the nature of the work to tweet, text, or phone a friend to feed their impressions, to snap a photo or make a quick video to send into virtual space. The installation not only incorporates the visitor but integrates a relational screen response in its very flow.

Layers Mama Layers rests on the phenomenon of screen multiplication and expansion in which we live, and it does so in interesting, conceptual ways that are seductively provocative. However, it shows an excessive degree of comfort with total screen immersion, a



4.14. Pipilotti Rist, *Layers Mama Layers*, 2010. Four projections (two moving, two fixed) on curtains, two moving mirrors, sound; dimensions variable. Courtesy of the artist and Luhring Augustine, New York.

problematic issue that is presented lightly and not really called into question. The sound of the installation reinforces this impression: ambient music creates a rhythm that compounds the effect of the ambient visuals. Counting sheep is no longer a way to put you to sleep. It is rather your computer that is asleep here. It's like endlessly staring at the screen saver with Pandora on a sonorous roll.

The wallpaper on your screen, or rather the wallpaper that is your screen, has become an extensive, extended environment. It is not by chance that this work by Pipilotti Rist appears in the era of such films as *Avatar* (2009), James Cameron's own response to, and recreation of, immersive environments. The installation renders an effect of total immersion that is similar to the one the Imax screen strives to achieve. Its plastic form is not far removed from the dimensionality of this screen. It resonates with the coterminous insistence on immersive dimensions and the return to the technique of 3D, which literally try to explode the frame of the filmic screen inward and outward to make its visual aspect into a surrounding space, equal to surround sound. In the immensely popular *Put Your Body Out* (2008–2009), Rist's multimedia installation set in the atrium of the Museum of Modern Art in New York, one senses a similar desire to be fully incorporated in this surface environment.

The question here is the degree of difference—as well as the connection—between absorption and immersion.⁴⁰ While the form of “superficial” absorption that I have theorized in both digital and nondigital work engages a projective relation of transformative becoming between subject and object, immersion involves a more pleasing, attractive engagement that, in its focus on extending sensory pleasures, is not as invested in destabilizing the subject's position or its becoming. One form, however, does not exclude the other, for absorption is itself a form of surface pleasure, and immersion involves criticality, however differently configured. And, as we have shown, there can be absorbent effects of immersive screening. In this sense, *Layers Mama Layers* is interesting for our purposes, for it exposes the virtual intimacy that is created with the digital screen as one holds this screen close to oneself in “touching” interaction. Here, the transformative web of relations that the material of surface can hold in the digital age is conceptually palpable in seductive ways.

As is the case with Tara Donovan's attractive proliferating plasticity, which is a distinct product of the digital era, or with Pae White's digital screen-curtain, Rist's form of screening also suggests we should think further about the process of rematerialization that the digital can convey, including the forms of relatedness it can afford us and the public intimacy that results from a refashioned relational screening process. As one wanders through the layers of these scrim-curtains, this digital situation reminds us that there are not only interruptions to but also continuities with the complex dynamics that we have seen developed on the fabric of the filmic screen.

In fact, at some level, the sculptural fabric of these works renders effects of virtual materiality to which the filmic canvas was not alien. It, too, was able to function like a curtain that moves in the wind. And now the screen has become an actual curtain. It is so light that when you move through it, it moves too, as it moves you. You may no longer feel trepidation

at touching this screen-curtain, or reverent amazement in traversing its space, for by now you are quite used to this haptic activity of spectating. This scrim has the familiarity of a mnemonic canvas. As you move through the layers of its fabric, you are reminded how, at the origin of the medium, cinema too hung on a veiled surface. Film required a sheet of cloth hanging on a wall to make its own curtained yet open space of traversal. And so the textured materiality of screen space persists, reinvented through the layers of the digital, reimprinted on the surface like a trace of memory, or a stain in its fabric.

